

# Butternut Squash Mac & Cheese

This rich and creamy butternut squash mac and cheese has hints of roasted squash whirled into a cheesy sauce flavored with fresh sage for a delicious plant-based meal any day of the week. We call for pre-chopped butternut squash to keep prep at a minimum, but feel free to chop your own or experiment with another winter squash like honeynut or acorn squash in place of the butternut.

By **Amanda Stanfield** | Updated on August 24, 2025

 Reviewed by Dietitian **Emily Lachtrupp, M.S., RD**

**Active Time:** 45 mins

**Total Time:** 55 mins

**Servings:** 6

## Nutrition Profile:

No Added Sugar Gut Healthy Mediterranean Diet Sesame-Free Nut-Free Soy-Free High-Fiber Vegetarian High-Protein Egg-Free

## Ingredients

3 cups peeled and cubed butternut squash

1 medium yellow onion, quartered

4 cloves garlic, peeled

1 tablespoon extra-virgin olive oil

$\frac{3}{4}$  cup whole milk

12 ounces whole-wheat elbow pasta (about 3 cups)

3 tablespoons unsalted butter

8 large fresh sage leaves

3 tablespoons all-purpose flour

$1\frac{1}{4}$  cups unsalted vegetable broth

1 cup shredded sharp Cheddar cheese

3 ounces garlic-and-herb spreadable cheese (such as Boursin; about  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup)

2 teaspoons Dijon mustard

$\frac{1}{2}$  teaspoon salt

$\frac{1}{2}$  teaspoon ground pepper

## Directions

### Step 1

Preheat oven to 425°F. Bring a large pot of water to a boil over high heat.

### Step 2

Meanwhile, combine 3 cups squash, onion, garlic and 1 tablespoon oil on a large rimmed baking sheet; toss until well coated. Roast until the squash is tender and browned, 25 to 30 minutes. Transfer the mixture to a blender; add  $\frac{3}{4}$  cup milk. Secure the lid on the blender and remove the center piece to allow steam to escape. Place a clean towel over the opening. Process until smooth, about 2 minutes.

### Step 3

Add 12 ounces pasta to the boiling water; cook until al dente, about 8 minutes. Drain and set aside. Reserve the pot.

### Step 4

Cook 3 tablespoons butter in the pot over medium heat until foamy, about 1 minute. Add 8 sage leaves in an even layer; fry until slightly transparent and dark green, about 1 minute. Carefully remove and transfer to a paper-towel-lined plate. Reserve the butter in the pot.

### Step 5

Add 3 tablespoons flour to the reserved butter in the pot; cook over medium heat, whisking constantly, until the mixture smells nutty, about 1 minute. Gradually whisk in  $1\frac{1}{4}$  cups broth; cook, whisking, until smooth and thickened, about 2 minutes. Reduce heat to low; whisk in the squash puree, 1 cup Cheddar,  $\frac{1}{2}$  cup spreadable cheese, 2 teaspoons mustard and  $\frac{1}{2}$  teaspoon each salt and pepper; cook, whisking constantly, until warmed through and smooth, 2 to 3 minutes. Add the cooked pasta; cook, stirring often, until warmed through, about 1 minute. Transfer to a large bowl. Garnish with the fried sage leaves.

## Frequently Asked Questions

### How should I store leftovers and reheat them?

Store leftovers in an airtight container for up to 4 days in the refrigerator. You can reheat the mac and cheese on the stovetop over medium-low heat or use the microwave.

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### Can I use a different type of pasta?

Absolutely, and if you make this a lot, it's fun to switch things up. Cavatappi and shells would be good substitutes for the elbow pasta.

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### How do I choose the best butternut squash and chop it?

When shopping for fresh whole butternut squash, choose one that weighs about 2 pounds to get the 3 cups you need for this recipe. The squash should be a creamy tan color with a matte (not shiny) finish, heavy for its size and free of soft spots. To prep it, cut the top off, poke the squash with holes using the tines of a fork and cook it in the microwave for 3 minutes. Let it cool a little

so it is easier to peel and chop. Halve the squash and scoop out and discard the seeds. Then peel the squash and cut the flesh into uniform cubes so it roasts evenly.

**What should I serve with Butternut Squash Mac and Cheese?**



An ideal side for a hearty mac and cheese dish like this one would be a green salad like our Herb & Arugula Salad with Balsamic Vinaigrette, Spinach Salad with Ginger-Soy Dressing or Basic Green Salad with Vinaigrette. You can also serve it with cooked green vegetables, such as broccolini, Brussels sprouts or green beans.

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**Nutrition Facts**

Per serving: **Serving Size about 1½ cups** 483 calories; total fat 22g; saturated fat 11g; cholesterol 51mg; sodium 490mg; total carbohydrate 57g; dietary fiber 7g; total sugars 5g; added sugars 0g; protein 19g; vitamin c 17mg; calcium 342mg; iron 3mg; potassium 533mg

*Additional reporting by Sarah Pflugrad, Ph.D., RDN, CSCS and Linda Frahm*

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